▶ UTTAR PRADESH

NO PLACE IN AGRA FOR TAJ OF SWEETS

The Agra *petha* is as much a part of the city's cultural confection as its architectural twin, the Taj. Pollution fears now put the padlocks on Noori Gate, its old abode



ASHISH MISRA

SUGARY LEGACY A *petha* manufacturing unit in the Noori Gate area of Agra

Takeaways

- **A Supreme Court ruling ends a long story, forcing *petha*-makers out of Agra**
- **Many are small family-run units, can't afford to shift to a new '*petha* city' 30 km away**

up the Gilauri Patta, a special sweet made from *petha*. "I make *petha* on the ground floor of my two-storey house," he says. "It's a cottage industry for my family. If I shift out, I won't be able to bear the costs. I'll have to stop."

Noori Gate has over 500 small and big units related to *petha* production. Over 5,000 people work here, churning out some 1,000 quintals of *petha* daily. For about three decades, the locality has attracted the attention of disapproving government planners due to an ironic inversion of the *petha*'s relation to the Taj: the fear that pollution caused by this sweet-making industry could be damaging the heritage monument.

On April 3, the Supreme Court ordered the evacuation of *petha* units from the city. It was hearing cases related to the Taj Trapezium Zone (TTZ), a designated 10,400 sq. km area around the Taj, established to protect it from pollution. After this, the Agra administration and the Uttar Pradesh Pollution Control Board (UPPCB) have started surveying these *petha* units.

Pollution is indeed an issue. After the TTZ was set up in 1983, the use of coal in kilns was banned and *petha* units adopted gas-based technology. In 2013, the UPPCB imposed a complete ban on the entry of coal-laden trucks into Agra. But problems persisted. According to a 2021 study by the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE), the city's *petha* industry generates about 17,800 kg of solid waste per day, mostly *petha* peels, sugar syrup and lime water. District officials say a campaign was launched in 2018 to educate *petha* producers about the importance of proper waste disposal, also granting aid to the big players to procure equipment for it. A large part of the industry, though, falls under the unorganised sector, beyond the pale of government benefits.

The traders deny *petha* pollution, and say the incriminating data is from a 25-year-old survey. Says Rajesh Agarwal, a leading voice from the organised part of the industry: "Now all the units run on gas furnaces. The peel was earlier identified as waste, but now they use it as animal feed. They should conduct a fresh survey."

Dr Devashish Bhattacharya, an ENT surgeon who's fighting a case in the National Green Tribunal (NGT) against *petha* pollution, is still sympathetic to their fate. "If all facilities were provided on time by the government, the *petha* makers would not have faced any problem," he says. Now, they face the gloomy prospect of shifting to the New Petha City in Kalindi Vihar, a 1999-vintage plan on which none of the traders were consulted.

A bitter end looms to a long story. ■